

"Men who opt to marry these women feel they deserve to be happy."

RENU SINHA, SUPERINTENDENT, WOMEN PROBATION HOME, RANCHI

nising the marriages. "The matrimonial process begins when an inmate agrees to tie the nuptial knot. Once this is done, a look-out for the suitable boy begins," says the state Additional Inspector General of Prisons (IGP), Deepak Vidyarthi. This is usually done by publishing matrimonial advertisements in local newspapers. "Once we find someone genuinely interested in marrying an inmate we follow it up with a stringent verification process," says Vidyarthi.

Just like any other Indian marriage, where friends and intermediaries trail the bridegroom to check his credentials, probation officials located in different districts are asked to verify the credentials of the men who wish to marry these girls. After scrutinising the details, the officials release a verification certificate. During this process, assistance of local police, local NGOs and health officials is sought and taken, who help the officials of the home complete background checks. Medical certificates, including HIV status (to rule out the possibility of the groom suffering from AIDS), are also examined. "The responsibility does not end here. We make sure that the local officials keep us updated about the girls' well-being even after their marriage," says Sunil Barnwal, the state IGP.

Tying the knot has improved many lives. For Sawita, a former inmate, who married a Ranchi-based carpenter William Bhengra in 2003, life couldn't have been better. "I was forced to stay at my uncle's place after I lost my parents early in life. My uncle wanted to usurp the property, so he lodged a false theft case against me. I was caught and sent to this probation home," says Sawita, a mother of two. "But I am happy with him (William) now. I have a television and my own house in Ranchi," she adds. The 28-year-old now wants to provide the best possible education to her children.

Mamta Devi, another former inmate of the probation home, happily married now, is busy looking for her lost family. Living with her husband at

Katkamsand, she visits Dhanbad every three to four months in search of her parents. She had left her house in a moment of fury after a fight with her mother. "That was when I was very young. I was caught by the police in Delhi and sent to a remand home. A few years later, they sent me to this probation home because I told them I was from Dhanbad," she recalls. "I have a family now but I wish to trace my parents. I know it will make them happy too," she says.

But the sad tales of these women

of the neighbouring Hazaribag district married Mamta because he was genuinely concerned about such women, says Sinha.

To make it a more popular initiative, the state Government has decided to grant a cash amount of Rs 25,000, besides several household items, including crockery set, a sewing machine and a television set, to help an inmate begin a new life outside the institution. The Chief Minister Kanyadaan Yojna—a special scheme initiated by the state Government in



▲ MAINEE AND SANJAY KARMAKAR

A lawyer in the state high court, Karmakar feels sorry for these hapless women and thinks that even they have a right to lead a happy life.

"My sister committed suicide because of dowry. I wanted to make a difference."

would not have had a happy ending without the initiative of the men who offered to marry them. In most cases men have decided to marry an inmate because they strongly feel that even these women have a right to lead a happy life. Mainee's prospective husband is one such person. "I decided to marry a destitute to send out a strong message against dowry. My sister committed suicide because her husband used to harass her for dowry. I want to make a difference now," says Karmakar, who practices in the state high court. Jagdish Mahto

2005 to ensure grants for the marriages of poor women—has become the mainstay of this initiative.

The probation home has set the wedding bells ringing for two fortunate girls for now. As for the rest, these preparations will follow a high-octane celebration, coupled with an extravagant dinner—all at the expense of the state Government. And as the guardians of the law, often vilified seldom gratified, prepare to comfort those who were once in conflict with it, many more girls can look forward to living happily ever after. ■